BISACODYL

Don't crush tablets

Bowel prep

CHEMICAL NAME 4,4′-(pyridin-2-ylmethylene)bis(phenyl acetate)
CLASS Stimulant laxative (diphenylmethane)
TRADE NAMES Dulcolax · Bisalax · Correctol

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Constipation (short-term).
- Bowel preparation before procedures/surgery.
- Opioid-induced constipation (with softener).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Stimulates **colonic myenteric plexus** → ↑ peristalsis; ↓ water absorption → ↑ intestinal secretion.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** enteric-coated tablets swallowed whole at bedtime — not within 1 h of antacids or milk (premature dissolution, gastric irritation).
- **PR** suppository — acts within 15–60 min.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Abdominal cramps, colic.
- Diarrhoea.
- Rectal irritation (suppository).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Electrolyte imbalance (hypokalaemia), dehydration with overuse.
- Atonic colon with chronic misuse (debated).

DOSAGES

- **Adult & ≥12 yr PO:** 5–10 mg at night (US label up to 15 mg).
- **PR (≥12 yr):** 10 mg suppository once daily; retain 15–20 min.
- **Children 6–<12 yr:** 5 mg PO once daily (US label); not under 12 yr in UK OTC pack.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Intestinal obstruction, acute abdomen (appendicitis), inflammatory bowel disease flare.
- Severe dehydration.
- Children <4 yr (without advice).

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Antacids, PPIs, milk:** dissolve coating → gastric irritation.
- **Diuretics, steroids:** ↑ hypokalaemia.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** PO 6–12 h; PR 15–60 min.
- Hydrolysed to active form in colon; minimal absorption.
- Excreted in faeces.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Rule out obstruction (pain, distension, vomiting).
- Give tablets at night for morning effect.
- Ensure toilet access/commode.
- Monitor K^+ with frequent use.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Swallow tablets whole; avoid milk or antacids for 1 h.
- Expect a bowel movement the next morning.
- Use short-term; increase fibre, fluids and activity.

KEY POINTS

- Stimulant laxative.
- Swallow whole; avoid milk/antacids.
- PO 6–12 h; PR 15–60 min.
- Not in obstruction.

SOURCES CHECKED **[555]** Bisacodyl 5mg Laxative Tablets 12+ years (UK SmPC) **[556]** Bisacodyl Laxative, rectal (US label)
Full references p. 432–457